Columbus, GA & Phenix City, AL

The Columbus Home Buyer's Checklist

Every step from pre-approval to keys, with notes for VA loans and Fort Benning moves.

Felecia Saunders
Associate Broker/Owner
NextHome Infinite Real Estate Solutions
Licensed in Georgia and Alabama



1 Get ready — Before you look at homes

- ☐ Check your credit report and fix any errors
- ☐ Pick a monthly payment you're comfortable with, not just the most you qualify for
- ☐ Gather documents: 2 years of W-2s or tax returns, recent pay stubs, 2 months of bank statements, photo ID
- ☐ Get pre-approved by a lender (stronger than pre-qualified)
- ☐ **VA buyers:** ask your lender to pull your Certificate of Eligibility (COE)
- ☐ Call Felecia to talk through your budget, must-haves and timeline

2 Shop for homes — Find the right fit

- ☐ Split your list into must-haves and nice-to-haves
- ☐ Choose areas to compare: Columbus, Phenix City, Harris County, Fort Mitchell, near Fort Benning
- ☐ Tour homes in person, or by video if you're still out of town
- ☐ Drive the commute at the hours you'll actually travel
- ☐ **PCS move:** share your report date so we can plan backward from it

3 Make an offer — Write it to win, and protect yourself

- ☐ Review recent nearby sales with Felecia to choose your price
- ☐ Decide on earnest money and your due diligence (inspection) period
- ☐ Confirm what stays with the home, like appliances
- ☐ Sign the purchase agreement

4 Under contract — The busy middle

- ☐ Deposit your earnest money on time
- ☐ Schedule the home inspection and negotiate any repairs
- ☐ Order a termite (wood-destroying insect) inspection, usually required for VA loans
- ☐ Complete the appraisal (a VA appraisal for VA loans)
- ☐ Shop for homeowners insurance
- ☐ Answer your lender's document requests quickly
- ☐ Hold off on new credit cards, car loans or big purchases

5 Closing day Keys in hand

- [ ] Review your Closing Disclosure, which you'll get at least 3 business days before closing
- [ ] Do a final walk-through of the home
- [ ] **Wire fraud alert:** call your closing office at a number you trust to confirm wiring instructions before sending money
- [ ] Bring your photo ID
- [ ] Sign, get your keys and celebrate

Questions to ask before you make an offer

- [ ] How long has it been on the market, and has the price dropped?
- [ ] How old are the roof, heating and air, and water heater?
- [ ] What do utilities usually cost each month?
- [ ] Are there HOA fees or neighborhood rules?
- [ ] Is the home in a flood zone?
- [ ] Any known repairs or past insurance claims?

Buying in Georgia

In Georgia, a closing attorney handles the closing. Your contract usually includes a due diligence period, which is your window for inspections.

Buying across the river in Alabama

Phenix City and Fort Mitchell have their own tax rates and closing customs. Felecia is licensed in both states and can walk you through the differences.

My home buying plan

Pre-approved amount

Lender and phone

Monthly payment I'm comfortable with

Move-in or PCS report date

Must-haves

Areas I like

Ready to start?

Felecia will help you build your plan, from pre-approval to closing.

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